

PC Elitism

ALMOST without exception and for as long as we can remember, all of us in the Digit Team have been PC gaming enthusiasts. We've had PCs from the time of the good old days of the 486 (some even before that!) and grew up on a healthy dose of 'Prince' and 'Dave', among other vintage games. All this makes this month's edition of Digit all the more special. In essence, we are going back to our roots, and paying homage in our own way to one of the most influential devices to have made its way into our lives.

As with any niche interest, over time, the love for PCs around the world has bred a sort of fanatical subculture that extols the virtues of using PCs over consoles for gaming. The self-proclaimed PC Master Race looks down at the 'Console Peasants' and has been seemingly engaged in a constant, never-ending feud for years. For the most part though, it's all harmless tongue-in-cheek fun. Personally, apart from thoroughly enjoying the memes this subculture has spawned, I find the feud a little odd, especially in today's context. In a world where people are dropping PC purchases to go for ARM-based mobiles as their primary computing devices, and where consoles are anyway x86, the PC vs. console war seems almost silly. And PC Elitism sure seems a little unwarranted.

Yes, there are certain arguments against consoles that make total sense. The games are absurdly priced for one thing, and the "exclusives" nonsense is such an obvious corporate ploy that I'm surprised most people don't see through it. Even the processing power falls short, at least on the specs sheet, because for one thing since there's no option to upgrade, there's no question of scalability. From a personal standpoint, I've forever been put off by the aim-assists that most console games incorporate. It just seems like cheating or a deliberate dumbing-down of things. Then again, trying to play FPS games with controllers would indeed be ridiculous. A mouse is so much better for that kind of stuff. And while on the topic of controllers, it's funny how the Master Race has allowed this peasant paraphernalia to find a home for itself in their hallowed halls, but that's a story for another day.

Despite well-documented drawbacks of consoles, they do serve a purpose. Even back in the day, I remember having a ton of fun playing Twisted Metal (split screen) or Tekken with my buddies from school. Replicating those kind of

experiences on a PC isn't really possible or at the very least, cumbersome.

In the other corner, PC enthusiasts argue that money spent on a PC is money well spent. Totally agree since the PC offers so much more than just gaming.

But is the PC objectively superior in every aspect, as the PC Master Race community would like you to believe? I'm a little skeptical. The casual gamer doesn't need an elaborate setup. Such a gamer might just want a quick party trick or a few minutes to kill in between Netflix binge sessions. Speaking of living-room entertainment, there's no denying that couch gaming is best done with a console. Sure, you could craft complicated furniture to support a keyboard and mouse but out of the box, a console is much more suitable to be paired with your TV.

Now for the elephant in the room – graphics. There's no denying that high-end PCs have enough grunt to enable visuals that could make your eyes bleed glorious tears of joy. While I'll be the first to admit that gaming on a 144Hz monitor feels buttery smooth, I'm not quite sure about the incremental benefits of pushing that to 240Hz. Besides, despite the awesome hardware that was launched this year, with the cryptomining boom and the resultant scarcity of GPUs that it led to, 2017 hasn't been the best for those trying to enter the PC fold. And while I haven't played too much on modern consoles, whatever little I saw of Gran Turismo and World Of Tanks on the PS4 Pro (in the Digit Test labs this month) - I found to be good enough. I could never imagine playing PUBG on one of these things, but hey horses for courses right?

As a gamer, at the end of the day, I only care about the games – irrespective of the platform they exist on. While some say PC gaming is slowly transforming into a purely multiplayer and microtransaction driven industry, a strong argument can be made for how consoles have been responsible for supporting compelling AAA single player experiences from certain studios (the console's very survival depends on them).

In conclusion, why can't we just enjoy both sides of this technology equation. I love my PC but I certainly don't discount the possibility of ever owning a console. In fact, getting one might even be essential to having a well-rounded gaming experience.

What is your take on this whole PC superiority debate? Do write in with your thoughts. 



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Reach me at:
facebook.com/
staticsid | @staticsid |
editor@digit.in